Chapter 3

What is value? Where does it come from? A psychological perspective

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Introduction

To understand why people do what they do, why they feel what they feel, psychologists need to know what matters to them, what they want and don't want. A central concept concerned with "mattering" and "wanting" is *value*. Indeed, Allport (1961: 543) suggested that value priorities were the "dominating force in life." The more an object or activity has value to us, the more we prefer it over alternative objects or activities. We want to have the object or do the activity. But what gives an object or activity its value? *Where does value come from?* This chapter considers several psychological mechanisms that confer value on something. Some of these mechanisms, such as satisfying a need or giving us hedonic pleasure, are well-known to be desired results that would confer value. Other mechanisms, as we will see, are less well-known and even surprising.

Let us begin at the beginning—the *hedonic principle*. The term "hedonic" derives from the Greek term for "sweet," and it means relating to, or characterized by, pleasure (Webster's Ninth New Collegiate Dictionary 1989). From the time of the Greeks, hedonic experiences have been linked to the classic motivational principle that people *approach pleasure and avoid pain*. Jeremy Bentham made an influential and explicit early statement on the importance of hedonic experiences to both ethical and non-ethical value (Bentham 1781/1988: 1): "Nature has placed mankind under the governance of two sovereign masters, *pain* and *pleasure*. It is for them alone to point out what we ought to do, as well as to determine what we shall do. On the one hand the standard of right and wrong, on the other the chain of causes and effects, are fastened to their throne." So, apparently, we have our answer: Value comes from having pleasure and not having pain (see: also Ellingsen et al., this volume).

But hold on! Let us go back even further and consider the beginning of the beginning—the Genesis story of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden as told in the *Bible*:

> And out of the ground made the Lord God to grow every tree that is pleasant to the sight, and good for food; the tree of life also in the midst of the garden, and the tree of knowledge of good and evil. . . . And the Lord God commanded the man, saying, Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat: But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it: for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die.
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> Genesis 2: 8–9, 16–17 (King James Version)

What I find remarkable about the Genesis story is that Adam and Eve chose to go against God's command. They chose to eat the fruit from the *tree of knowledge*. What could possibly motivate them to make this choice when, by making it, they would "surely die" (or at minimum be banished from paradise)? By making this choice, they would lose paradise, lose an everlasting life of pleasure and no pain—everlasting because they *were* allowed to eat the fruit from the tree of life. If the hedonic principle is correct, if what people really want is to maximize pleasure and minimize pain, why would Adam and Eve have made this choice? What is this story telling us about human motivation?

I believe the answer lies in the fruit being from the *tree of knowledge*. The tree of *knowledge* is the tree of *truth* and a central motivation of humans is to *establish what's real*, to distinguish between truth and falsehood, between reality and fantasy. This motivation for the truth can be as important to humans as life itself (see: Higgins 2007, 2012). Moreover, the tree of knowledge is not just any knowledge—it is the "*tree of the knowledge of good and evil*." This means that eating the fruit of this tree also satisfies another central human motivation—the motivation to *manage what happens*, the motivation to *control* our lives. Humans can only be in control of their lives when they have the knowledge of what is good and what is evil. And when you combine truth and control—when truth and control *work together* as in the tree of the knowledge of good and evil—then humans can live a life in which they *"go in the right direction*."

It is notable that Adam and Eve's life in the Garden of Eden had little need for truth or control because everything was provided for them in this paradise. This would be fine if what people really valued was having pleasure and no pain. But people want a life in which *they* go in the right direction and for this to happen they must be effective at having truth and control (see: Higgins 2012). This is why they needed to eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. What the Genesis story captures is that there is more to what humans value that just having pleasure, just having desired outcomes. As Carl Rogers said, "The good life is a process, not a state of being. It is a direction, not a destination" (Rogers 1995/1961).

When people are effective in truth and control, their *engagement* in goal pursuits is strengthened. Stronger engagement in goal pursuits makes people "feel alive" and contributes to well-being. And it does something else as well. It intensifies the value experience itself. It makes attractive things even more attractive, and it makes repulsive things even more repulsive. Not only is the journey itself more worthwhile, but stronger engagement impacts the value intensity of *the destination itself*. This is the major takeaway message of this chapter. But before I discuss how regulatory engagement works psychologically and provide evidence for its impact on value, I need to review other psychological mechanisms that impact whether something is experienced as being positive or negative to begin with. This important part of the story concerns where *valence* comes from.

Where does valence come from?

The basic psychological mechanisms that have been proposed traditionally as underlying whether something is experienced as positive or negative are: valence from need

satisfaction; valence from shared beliefs about desirable objectives and procedures; valence from relating our current selves to personal standards; valence from making evaluative inferences; and valence from hedonic experience. In this section, I will briefly review each of these psychological contributors to valence (for more extensive reviews, see: Brendl and Higgins 1996; Higgins 2007, 2012).

Valence from need satisfaction

At the turn of the twentieth century, psychologists with theoretical perspectives ranging from behavioristic to Gestalt to psychodynamic proposed that need satisfaction is the basic mechanism that confers value to objects and activities. Specifically, something has positive value if it contributes to satisfying physical needs, reduces drives or deficiencies, or increases an individual's survival in the world. If it does the opposite, it has negative value. Behavior is directed toward controlling deficits of specific substances in the body, and value derives from homeostatic responses to tissue deficits and physiological equilibrium (see: Weiner 1972). Drives were manifest in behavior, had physiological correlates, and naturally gave rise to man's desires (see: Woodworth 1918).

Using operant or classical conditioning to change attitudes, social-psychological research during the 1950s provided a broader version of the need satisfaction viewpoint, including need for approval. In one paradigm, for example, while the participants were talking to the experimenter, the experimenter casually responded positively to one set of linguistic forms the participants used, such as plural nouns, with approving head movements or expressions like "mm-hmmm" and did not respond positively to other linguistic forms, such as singular nouns. Over time, without participants' awareness, the approved linguistic forms were produced more frequently than the non-approved forms—as if those linguistic forms had increased in value (for a review of such studies, see: Eagly and Chaiken 1993).

Valence from people's shared beliefs about desirable objectives and procedures

A very different mechanism that confers value is people's *shared beliefs* about which ends or objectives, and which means or procedures for attaining these ends, are or are not generally desirable. This is the kind of value that people have in mind when they say that they value "freedom" or "equality." Although these values are personal in the sense of being internalized, they are acquired within a social context and are shared with others (Schwartz 1992). Milton Rokeach describes values as "shared prescriptive or proscriptive beliefs about ideal modes of behavior and end-states of existence" (see: Rokeach 1980: 262). Similarly, Robert Merton (1957: 133) notes that: "Every social group invariably couples its cultural objectives with regulations, rooted in the mores or institutions, of allowable procedures for moving toward these objectives."

The "shared beliefs" mechanism for conferring value includes *norms* about what goals are worth pursuing and what moral principles or standards of conduct one should live

by. As captured in the concept of "procedural justice" (see: Tyler and Lind 1992; Thibaut and Walker 1975), for example, people in many societies value the fairness of decision procedures independent of decision outcomes, such as employees wanting their managers to follow fair procedures in determining raises independent of whether they end up with a higher or lower raise themselves (see: Brockner 2010). Given the importance of shared cultural or socialized values as a mechanism that confers value for humans on the objects and activities in their lives, it is not surprising that such values have received special attention in social psychology (e.g., Rokeach 1973; Schwartz and Bilsky 1987; Seligman et al. 1996).

Valence from people relating themselves to standards

Shared beliefs can be considered not only at the broader societal level where the values apply to people in general, but also at the more interpersonal level where significant others apply values to a specific person. Whereas values from shared beliefs at the societal level are usually treated as social values, values from a person's shared beliefs with a significant other (e.g., mother, partner) are usually treated as personal standards. Historically, control process models have treated personal standards in terms of the relation between a current state of the self and some end-state functioning as a standard of reference. The value of the current self-state depends on the extent to which it approaches a desired end-state or avoids an undesired end-state (see: Carver and Scheier 1981, 1990; Miller et al. 1960; Powers 1973; Wiener 1948).

For human motivation, the desired and undesired end-states that function as reference points or guides for self-regulation are typically acquired from interactions with significant others. Developmentally, children learn their caretakers' hopes and aspirations for them (their *ideals*) or their caretakers' beliefs about their duties and responsibilities (their *oughts*). When children become capable of having their own standpoint on ideals and oughts, they can adopt their caretakers' ideals and oughts for them as their own, thereby creating a *shared reality* about desired end-states, which are *internalized* (or identified) *self-guides*. Ideal self-guides relate to the promotion system that is concerned with accomplishments and advancement, and ought self-guides relate to the prevention system that is concerned with safety and security (see: Higgins 1997). An actual-self attribute that is congruent with (matches) an ideal or ought self-guide has positive value, whereas an actual-self attribute that is discrepant from (mismatches) an ideal or ought self-guide has negative value (see: Higgins 1987, 1991; James, 1890/1948; Moretti and Higgins 1999; Rogers 1961).

Value is conferred by two different mechanisms in these systems. First, the person's ideal and ought standards of excellence are shared beliefs with significant others about which end-states have positive value and which have negative value. Second, the actual self-states that are congruent with, or discrepant from, the ideal and ought self-guides themselves have positive or negative values, respectively. It is this second mechanism of conferring value on actual self-states that uniquely characterizes this viewpoint on value. It introduces the notion of value from monitoring one's success or failure in meeting self-guides—value

from the answer to "how am I doing?" (see: Bandura 1986; Boldero and Francis 2002; Carver and Scheier 1990; Duval and Wicklund 1972; Higgins 1987, 1996).

Valence from hedonic experience

As I mentioned earlier, interest in hedonic experiences as a mechanism conferring value has continued over the centuries. From the ancient Greeks to seventeenth- and eighteenth-century British philosophers, to twentieth-century psychologists (see: Kahneman et al. 1999), the hedonic principle that people are motivated to approach pleasure and avoid pain has dominated our understanding of people's motivation. It is the basic motivational assumption of theories across all areas of psychology, including theories of emotion in psychobiology (e.g., Gray 1982), conditioning in animal learning (e.g., Mowrer 1960; Thorndike 1935), decision-making in cognitive psychology (e.g., Edwards 1955; Kahneman and Tversky 1979), consistency in social psychology (e.g., Festinger 1957; Heider 1958), and achievement motivation in personality (e.g., Atkinson 1964). Even in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle,* when Freud (1920/1950) assigned a motivational role to the ego's reality principle, he made it clear that the reality principle "at bottom also seeks pleasure although a delayed and diminished pleasure" (p. 365). More recently, Kahneman (2000) has distinguished "decision utility," where utility is inferred from observed choices (i.e., revealed in behavior), from "experienced utility" that involves experiences of pleasure and pain. Kahneman argues that the best way to measure actual experienced utility is by moment-based methods where experienced utility of an episode is derived from real-time measures of the pleasure and pain that an individual experienced during that episode.

The motivation for pleasure can be so important that it can even trump the motivation to satisfy basic biological needs. It has been known for over half a century that animals will choose on the basis of hedonic experiences independent of any biological need being satisfied (Eisenberger 1972). There are early studies, for example, showing not only that sweet water with saccharin is preferred to regular water, but also that animals prefer sweet food to a physiologically better food, such as a food that is more beneficial for an animal given its vitamin deficiency (for a review of these early studies, see: Woodsworth and Schlosberg 1954). There are also classic studies by James Old and Peter Milner showing that rats will work to press a bar that activates the pleasure area in the brain but does not satisfy any biological need (Olds and Milner 1954). In the original and follow-up studies, metallic electrodes were implanted in certain regions of the lateral hypothalamus and some rats would push the lever up to five-thousand times an hour, even to the point of collapsing. In a T-maze, with both arms baited with food mash, the rat would stop at a point halfway down the runway to self-stimulate, never going to the food at all. Some mother rats even abandoned their newborn pups—despite the biological imperative of mothers' caring for their infants—in order to press the lever thousands of times per hour.

At this point you might be telling yourself, "So I guess the Greeks had it right all along. Maximizing pleasure is the answer to what people really want." Well, I do believe that it *is* part of the answer. But I also believe that it only *part* of the answer, and given this, I believe

that there is a problem with its being anointed for centuries as being *the* answer. For too long it has dominated thinking about where value comes from. It has taken attention away from other contributions to the value of things. In the remainder of this chapter I will discuss four of these contributions: value from distinctly different ways to approach pleasure and avoid pain (i.e., promotion vs. prevention); value from being effective in establishing what's real (truth) and managing what happens (control); value from a fit between different ways of being effective (i.e., working together effectively); and value intensification from strengthening engagement.

Promotion and prevention as value beyond pleasure and pain

Where does the positive experience of success come from? Where does the negative experience of failure come from? You might think the answers are obvious: success is pleasant and failure is painful. But feeling relaxed after success is very different from feeling joyful after success. And feeling anxious after failure is very different from feeling sad. These are very different positive and negative value experiences and the hedonic principle is silent on these differences. Research testing self-discrepancy theory (see: Higgins 1987, 1989) found that these different positive and negative value experiences depended on whether the success or failure was in relation to people's personal ideals or personal oughts. Success or failure in relation to personal ideals produced emotions along the cheerfulness–dejection dimension (e.g., joyful–sad), whereas success or failure in relation to personal oughts produced emotions along the quiescence–agitation dimension (e.g., relaxed–anxious).

According to self-discrepancy theory, these different value experiences are produced by different psychological situations. When events are related to our ideals, we experience success as the presence of a positive outcome (a gain), which is a joyful experience, and we experience failure as the absence of positive outcomes (a non-gain), which is a sad experience. However, when events are related to our oughts, we experience success as the absence of a negative outcome (a non-loss), which is a relaxing experience, and we experience failure as the presence of a negative outcome (a loss), which is an anxious experience (see: Higgins and Tykocinski 1992; Strauman 1992).

Self-discrepancy theory was concerned with chronic personality differences in value experiences. But situations and events themselves can create different psychological situations that produce different kinds of positive value experiences and different kinds of negative value experiences. Regulatory focus theory (Higgins 1997, 1998) was developed to include these situational effects on value experiences and to try to understand more deeply the distinct ways that people experience positive value and negative value when they self-regulate within these different systems (as well as to examine other motivational effects of these different systems of self-regulation).

A transition point from self-discrepancy theory to regulatory focus theory occurred when Miguel Brendl and I began working on a chapter (for Mark Zanna's *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology* series) that addressed the question, "What makes events

positive or negative?" (Brendl and Higgins 1996). I remember Miguel coming in to my office with an air of excitement and telling me about a critical factor for understanding the nature of valence. His insight was that the nature of valence depended on the nature of neutrality: *to understand valence, you needed to understand "0."*

A critical principle for judging valence is *the principle of goal supportiveness,* which refers to the degree to which an event is judged to support or impede the satisfaction of a set goal, with goal support producing positive valence and goal impediment producing negative valence. This principle has a long history. Lewin, Dembo, Festinger, and Sears (1944), for example, assumed that a goal separates positively valenced events from negatively valenced events, or an area of success from an area of failure, with the former being approached and the latter being avoided. More recent theories of emotion also assume that reaching versus frustrating a goal (Lazarus 1993; Ortony et al. 1988; Roseman 1984) is experienced positively versus negatively. Brendl and Higgins (1996) considered what this meant for the difference between the (promotion) ideal system and the (prevention) ought system. We proposed that given the nature of ideal and ought goals, "0" in these systems was *not* neutral. Moreover, "0" had *a different valence* for (promotion) ideal and (prevention) ought goal pursuit.

For (promotion) ideal goal pursuit, successfully attaining a positive outcome supports the goal pursuit, because it represents the presence of a positive outcome, and as such it has positive valence. Not attaining a positive outcome impedes (promotion) ideal goal pursuit, because it represents the absence of a positive outcome, and as such has negative valence. This means that simply maintaining a status quo "0" is *not* experienced as neutral in the (promotion) ideal system of goal pursuit; instead, it has *negative* valence, because it fails to attain a positive outcome (fails to advance; a non-gain). In contrast, for (prevention) ought goal pursuit, maintaining a status quo "0" has *positive* valence, because it represents the absence of a negative outcome (a non-loss). Thus, once again, "0" is *not* experienced as neutral. But for (prevention) ought goal pursuit, "0" has positive valence rather than negative valence as for promotion ideal goal pursuit. What has negative valence for (prevention) ought goal pursuit is failing to maintain a status quo "0," which represents the presence of a negative outcome.

Many subsequent studies have supported these proposed valence differences between the promotion and prevention systems (for a recent review, see: Higgins 2014). What this means is that the hedonic principle alone is *not* sufficient to understand where valence comes from. The distinction between promotion and prevention systems of self-regulation must be taken into account.

The distinction between promotion and prevention goal pursuit also has implications for understanding the nature of moral or ethical value (see also Moll et al., 2015). Moral foundations' theory (Haidt and Graham 2007) proposes that moral judgments can be explained in terms of five moral foundations: "Harm/Care," "Fairness/Reciprocity," "Ingroup/Loyalty," "Authority/Respect," and "Purity/Sanctity." Ingroup/Loyalty is said to underlie our feelings of loyalty to groups to which we belong (such as the nation or family), Authority/Respect to our feelings that certain individuals deserve our respect and to the endorsement of hierarchy, and Purity/Sanctity to our feelings that associate nobility

with purity and the moral element of our feelings of disgust. They are considered "*binding*" foundations, because they generally involve the binding of individuals to larger institutions or groups such as a family, a nation, or a religious organization. Cornwell and Higgins (2013) have found that for both chronic and situationally induced focus, binding foundation endorsement is stronger for participants with a stronger prevention focus and is weaker for participants with a stronger promotion focus (independent of participants' political identification). This is consistent with previous evidence that a prevention focus, with its emphasis on duties and responsibilities, is more strongly associated with an interdependent (vs. independent) self-construal than is a promotion focus (Lee et al. 2000).

Truth and control as value beyond pleasure and pain

To return to the beginning of the beginning, the story of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden suggests that what matters to humans must be more than just having all pleasure and no pain. They want to be effective at establishing what's real (truth) and managing what happens (control) that is part of life's journey (Higgins 2012).

In answering the question of what is it that people want, what is it that they value, it is critical to go beyond pleasure and pain.[1] This is well illustrated by the value people assign to activities that often involve hardship and even intense suffering. Almost thirty years before Tenzing Norgay (from Nepal) and Edmund Hillary (from New Zealand) successfully climbed Mount Everest on May 29, 1953, British mountain climber George Mallory (in 1924) decided that he would attempt to climb Mount Everest, despite knowing the extreme dangers and hardships involved in such a climb. In fact, he and his climbing partner, Andrew Irvine, disappeared on the way to the summit. Given our common beliefs in "survival" and "pleasure" as what people really want, it is not surprising that, before he left on this dangerous venture, he was asked why he wanted to climb Mount Everest. His famous answer was, "Because it's there." It's not just about survival or just about pleasure. It's about succeeding at something—in this case succeeding at something that is extremely challenging.

George Mallory was not the first to engage in an extreme sport activity. And he was certainly not the last. Now we can even watch televised programs of people engaging in extreme sports, such as the X Games. But unlike the athletes in the X Games, most of those who engage in extreme sports are not competing against other athletes but are just competing against environmental obstacles and challenges. The sports are considered extreme

[1] In this chapter I will use the term "value" as a synonym for the more general term "worth" or "worthwhile." In my 2012 book, I have a more restricted meaning of "value" as "being effective at having desired results." Value is then distinguished from "being effective at establishing what's real' (truth) and "being effective at managing what happens" (control). Because the present Handbook is concerned with value in the more general sense of "worth" or "worthwhile," I have chosen here to discuss value in this more general sense as well. In this more general sense, being effective in truth and in control also have value.

precisely because the environmental weather and terrain conditions are inherently uncontrollable, such as a sudden storm, and need to be dealt with on the spot. The athletes in these sports say that what they value in these sports is testing their ability to master difficult environments. As one example, a famous paraglider pilot, Bob Drury, is quoted as saying, "We do these things not to escape life, but to prevent life escaping us."

The value from control, from managing to make something happen, is independent from being just a means for obtaining desired outcomes (i.e., instrumental value). Consider, for example, a study with rats that learned that by pressing a lever they could make a food pellet fall into a food tray where they could eat it. In one experimental condition, a food dish containing the exact same food pellets was placed in the cage, which meant that the rats could obtain the same food pellets for free (i.e., without having to work for them). On occasion a rat would accidentally push the free food dish in front of the food tray. Despite the fact that they could effortlessly attain the food from the free food dish in front of them, the rats actually pushed the food dish *out of the way* (not eating from it), and then pressed the lever to make a food pellet fall into the food tray where they ate it (Carder and Berkowitz 1970). This is not just instrumental behavior. If it were, the rats would eat from the free food dish, thereby maximizing the benefits/costs ratio given that it would be the same beneficial food for less cost in effort.

This is the value that derives from control, from managing to make something happen, even if it is painful to do so. There are similar examples of people suffering for the sake of the truth, taking on pain and suffering for the sake of establishing what's real and fighting for what's real. A well-known movie example occurs in the movie *The Matrix*. In this movie, the reality perceived by humans is actually a *simulated* reality—the Matrix—that provides people with a hedonically positive life to pacify them. Morpheus, the leader of the rebels, gives Neo a choice between a blue pill that will keep him in this comfortable simulated reality or a red pill that offers only the truth. Morpheus tells Neo, "All I'm offering is the truth, nothing more." Neo chooses the red pill.

For decades social psychologists have studied all the different ways that people value and seek the truth. The value of truth is reflected in people wanting to know "what" is happening (social judgments) and "why" it is happening (attributions), make sense of the relations among their beliefs, attitudes, and choices (consistency), and create norms and shared realities with others to establish agreement regarding what to feel and believe about the world (for reviews, see: Higgins 2012, 2013). What they want is the truth, "even if it hurts."

For an intuitive understanding of the value of truth and control over hedonic outcomes, consider the thought experiment offered by Robert Nozick in his book *Anarchy, State and Utopia* (Nozick 1974). He asks us to imagine an experience machine that could give us whatever pleasurable experiences we could possibly want. If you get into this machine, your pleasant experiences will be fully convincing; you would not be able to tell that they were not veridical. The inventor promises that for the rest of your life in the machine you will have a fully convincing experience of a life that is better than whatever would have happened to you outside the machine. Most people choose *not* to get into the machine.

This does not make sense if hedonic outcomes are all that we value. But people value truth and they consider what happens inside the machine to be an illusion rather than reality, inauthentic rather than authentic. And they value control, and inside the machine their life of successful outcomes occurs because of the *inventor's* control rather than *their* control. Thus, although they know that better outcomes will occur inside the machine, it will not be self-determined and it will not be authentic.

Value from fit

Earlier in this chapter I discussed how people value "going in the right direction," which involves control and truth working together effectively. One example of this is the value that individuals place on control when they are in the goal pursuit state of *locomotion* where they want to get "going" and keep "going," and the value that they place on truth when they are in the goal pursuit state of *assessment* where they want to do what's "right"; when they fit together we "go in the right direction." This value from fit has been shown to translate into effective performance, where the highest performance is found when individuals are high in both locomotion and assessment (Kruglanski et al. 2000).

Value from fit is also created when there is a fit between individuals' regulatory focus orientation (promotion; prevention) and their manner of goal pursuit (eager; vigilant). Manner of goal pursuit concerns effectively managing to make it happen (control). There is evidence that when there is fit (promotion–eager; prevention–vigilant) people "feel right" about, i.e., value, what they are doing. When there is non-fit (promotion–vigilant; prevention–eager) people "feel wrong" about what they are doing. Moreover, the "feel right" experience from fit in the goal pursuit activity can change the value of the goal object itself, intensifying its attractiveness (Higgins 2000).

In an early test of such value transfer from fit (Higgins et al. 2003), undergraduates at Columbia decided whether they preferred a Columbia coffee mug or an inexpensive pen. The manner in which they made this decision was manipulated by giving them different instructions prior to making their choice. Half of them were told to think about what they would *gain by choosing* the mug and what they would gain by choosing the pen—an *eager* manner of making a choice. The other half were told to think about what they would *lose by not choosing* the mug or what they would lose by not choosing the pen—a *vigilant* manner of making a choice. This manner of making a choice did not in itself influence their choice—almost all of them preferred the Columbia coffee mug over the pen—nor did it influence the perceived value of the mug (as reflected in what they were willing to pay to buy it). However, it created fit and non-fit conditions with the participants who were either predominant promotion or predominant prevention. Predominant promotion participants who made their decision eagerly and predominant prevention participants who made their decision vigilantly offered much more money to buy the mug than predominant promotion participants who made their decision vigilantly and predominant prevention participants who made their decision eagerly—almost 70 percent more money for the exact same mug!

Value from strength of engagement

When people pursue goals in a manner that fits their goal pursuit orientation, they not only "feel right" about what they are doing. They also become more strongly engaged in what they are doing. Other conditions of goal pursuit also influence how strongly people are engaged in what they are doing. As I mentioned in the beginning of this chapter, this impacts value in a couple of ways. To begin with, people "feel alive" when they are strongly engaged in what they are doing. This itself contributes to well-being in humans and other animals (for a review, see: Franks and Higgins 2012). It makes life's journey more worthwhile. But that is not all. It also changes the value of the destination itself by intensifying it. In this last section I will distinguish the contribution of engagement strength to value experiences from the contribution of hedonic experience, and I will present evidence for different sources of engagement strength that impact value.

Figure 3.1 provides an overall illustration of what *regulatory engagement theory* proposes as contributors to value experience (for a fuller discussion of regulatory engagement theory, see: Higgins 2006; Higgins and Scholer 2009). Hedonic experience is one contributing factor but there are other factors as well, including those like need satisfaction and standards that contribute to value experience through their impact on engagement strength. In discussing this proposal, I begin with the value experience itself on the far right side of Fig. 3.1. What exactly is the nature of this value experience?

For Lewin (1951), value related to *force*, which has direction and intensity. Lewin's concept of "force" can be extended to personal experiences that have direction and intensity.

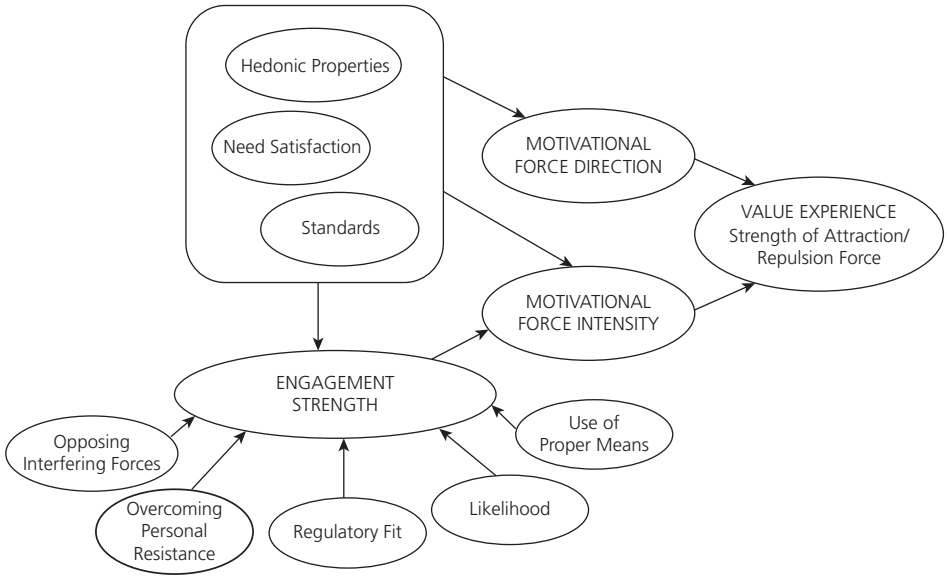


Fig. 3.1 Illustration of proposed relations among variables contributing to the value experience.

Experiencing something as having positive value corresponds to experiencing a force of attraction toward it, and experiencing something as having negative value corresponds to experiencing a force of repulsion from it. Value experiences vary in intensity. The experience of a force of attraction toward something can be relatively weak or strong (low or high positive value), and the experience of a force of repulsion from something can be relatively weak or strong (low or high negative value).

The factor of engagement strength is shown on the bottom left of Fig. 3.1. The state of being engaged is to be involved, occupied, and interested in something. Strong engagement is to concentrate on something, to be absorbed or engrossed with it (Higgins 2006). Strength of engagement alone does not make something attractive or repulsive; that is, it does not have direction. Instead, strength of engagement contributes to intensifying the force of attraction toward something or the force of repulsion away from something.

As illustrated in Fig. 3.1, value creation mechanisms such as need satisfaction, hedonic experience, and standards of different kinds all contribute to the direction of the motivational force, to whether the value force is positive attraction or negative repulsion. These mechanisms also contribute to the intensity of the motivational force, to how attractive or how repulsive something is. In contrast, strength of engagement, as illustrated in Fig. 3.1, only contributes to the intensity of the value experience. However, this contribution can be important. Different truth and control factors can contribute to the intensity of the value experience through their impact on engagement strength, including regulatory fit (which I have already discussed), use of proper means, opposing interfering forces, and likelihood (for fuller reviews, see: Higgins 2007, 2012).

Strengthening engagement by using proper means

Regulatory fit represents one kind of control effectiveness that strengthens engagement—effective use of a manner of goal pursuit that sustains one current goal orientation (e.g., eager manner for a promotion orientation). Another kind of control effectiveness that strengthens engagement is the use of proper or appropriate means when pursuing a goal—pursuing the goal in the *right way*. There are common maxims that suggest that pursuing goals in the right way contributes to value beyond the pains and pleasures of goal pursuit outcomes: "It is not enough to do good; one must do it in the right way" or "What counts is not whether you win or lose, but how you play the game." But the use of proper means need not involve behaving in a moral or ethical way in order for it to contribute to value. For example, James March (1994), a major figure in organizational decision-making, has proposed that pursuing goals in an appropriate or proper way has its own relation to value creation, separate from just hedonic outcomes.

Consider, for instance, what happens when individuals choose between a coffee mug and a pen. Some people might believe that the proper or right way to make this choice would be to list the positive and negative properties of the mug, then list the positive and negative properties of the pen, look over each list, and then make the choice. Making the choice in this way would not traditionally be considered a moral or ethical issue. But it

does involve our doing something in a proper or right way, and this can strengthen engagement in what we are doing. This stronger engagement in turn can intensify our attraction toward our ultimate choice—independent of the inherent properties of that choice. In recent studies we have investigated this possibility (see: Higgins et al. 2008).

Columbia undergraduates were asked to express their preference between a Columbia coffee mug and an inexpensive pen. As in our regulatory fit mug and pen study described earlier, we were only concerned with those participants who made the *same* choice—overwhelmingly the coffee mug. In one study, before the participants actually made their choice, they were randomly assigned to two different conditions that varied in what was emphasized about the decision. One condition emphasized the "Right Way"; it began with the title, "Making Your Decision in the RIGHT WAY!" and then continued as follows: "You need to make your decision in the *right way*. The right way to make a decision is to think about which choice has the better consequences. Think of the positive and negative consequences of choosing the mug. Think of the positive and negative consequences of choosing the pen. Please write down your thoughts on the lines below." The second condition emphasized the "Best Choice"; it began with the title, "The BEST CHOICE!" and then continued as follows: "The *best choice* is the choice with the better consequences. Think of the positive and negative consequences of owning the mug. Think of the positive and negative consequences of owning the pen. Please write down your thoughts on the lines below." Note that in both conditions the specific behaviors requested of the participants were exactly the same. What varied was whether those behaviors were perceived by the participants as making their decision in the right way (process) or as leading to the best future outcomes (outcome).

After considering the two options and expressing their preference, the participants were given the opportunity to buy the mug that they preferred. The study found that the participants in the *Right Way* condition offered much more money to buy the same chosen mug than participants in the *Best Choice* condition. But that was not all. This study also asked participants how much they agreed with three cultural maxims concerning the importance of pursuing goals in a proper way: "The end does not justify the means"; "What counts is not whether you win or lose, but how you play the game."; and (reverse coded) "To do it this way or that, it does not matter– results are all that count." Stronger engagement in the *Right Way* condition should only happen for those participants with strong beliefs in pursuing goals in a proper way. Indeed, for those participants with only weak beliefs, there was no significant difference between the *Right Way* and *Best Choice* conditions. But for participants with strong beliefs in pursuing goals in a proper way, the money offered to buy the mug was much higher in the *Right Way* condition than the *Best Choice* condition—$6.35 in the *Right Way* condition versus $2.61 in the *Best Choice* condition. Other findings also supported the conclusion that pursuing goals in the right way strengthens engagement in what we are doing, which intensifies attraction toward a positively valued object.

Strengthening engagement by opposing interfering forces

There is a third kind of control effectiveness that can strengthen engagement and intensify value—*opposing interfering forces*. My collaborators and I investigated this mechanism by examining different ways of dealing with adversity. It is common for people to confront difficulties while they pursue their goals. Obstacles in the path toward a goal have to be removed. Forces pushing back from the goal have to be resisted. Aversive background conditions must be dealt with. Higgins, Marguc, and Scholer (2012) investigated whether the direction of change in the value of a positive goal pursuit object (more attractive *vs*. less attractive) would depend on how people dealt with an adversity.

When people encounter adversity in goal pursuit, they can either redouble their focus on the task at hand—the kind of response to difficulty that Woodworth (1940) described as resistance, as illustrated by leaning into a wind that is impeding one's forward progress—or they can direct their attention away from the task at hand and attend instead to something else, such as their unpleasant feelings. More specifically, one way of dealing with an unpleasant background noise is to represent it as something that is interfering with the goal pursuit and must be opposed in order to succeed on the focal task. This "*opposing an interference*" response should strengthen engagement with the focal task activity, which would *increase* attraction toward a positive goal object. Alternatively, one could treat the background noise as something producing unpleasant feelings that must be coped with. This "*coping with a nuisance*" response should weaken engagement with the focal task, which would *decrease* attraction toward a positive goal object.

Supposedly to simulate real-world conditions in which people have to deal with unpleasant ambient noise while they are working, participants worked in the presence of an aversive background noise to solve enough anagrams to receive a prize. The noise was the same for everyone and consisted of a series of different animal sounds (e.g., birds, sheep, horse, bear). Participants in the "*opposing*" condition were told, "the background noise is something you will have to overcome in order to attend to the task," and "to do well on the task, you will need to overcome the distraction and oppose its interference." Participants in the "*coping*" condition were told, "the background noise is a bit of a nuisance to cope with. It is something that may cause you to feel a bit unpleasant—a feeling that you'll need to cope with." All participants won the lottery ticket for the prize. Participants then indicated how much they valued this prize.

At the end of the study, there was a surprise recognition task for the content of the background noise. This measure checked on whether the participants followed the instructions on what to attend to during the task. The more attention they paid to dealing with the adversity as instructed (whether it was opposing or coping), the worse their memory would be for the content of the background noise. For those participants who did pay attention as instructed, the value of the prize changed in opposite directions (as predicted): for those who paid attention to opposing the background noise as an interfering force (strengthening engagement in the focal anagram task), the positive value of the prize increased (intensified attraction); for those who paid attention to coping with the unpleasant feelings

created by the background noise (weakening engagement in the focal anagram task), the positive value of the prize decreased (deintensified attraction).

What this research highlights is that adversities, although unpleasant, do not necessarily make positive things in life less positive. Adversities can have this diminishing effect when people deal with them by disengaging from what they are doing in order to cope with the unpleasant feelings produced by the adversities. Such disengagement would decrease the positivity of positive things. But if people instead oppose adversities as interfering forces and redouble their focus on what they are doing, i.e., strengthen their engagement, then dealing with adversities can actually make positive things in life even more positive. These findings extend current models of how obstacles affect value by providing evidence that *how* adversity is dealt with plays a critical role in whether adversity increases or decreases the value of something.

Strengthening engagement by using high likelihood expressions

Thus far I have considered how mechanisms of *control* effectiveness can intensify (or deintensify) the positive value of something through strengthening (or weakening) engagement. In this section I will describe how a mechanism of *truth* effectiveness can both intensify the positive value of a positive object *and* intensify the negative value of a negative object by strengthening *preparatory engagement* for something that will *really* happen.

The concept of likelihood holds a special place in psychology and other disciplines studying judgment and decision-making. In psychology and economics, the concept of likelihood is perhaps best known for its role within the model of *subjective expected utility* (SEU). This model assumes that the possible outcomes from taking some action are disjunctive; that is, the outcomes are *mutually exclusive* alternatives, joined by "or." In addition, the outcomes are *exhaustive*, capturing all of the possible outcomes. In the simple case of succeeding or failing on a task, success and failure as outcomes are mutually exclusive and exhaustive. There is a subjective probability of success and a subjective probability of failure, summing to 100 percent (see: Atkinson 1957).

In a SEU model, beliefs about the probability of a specific outcome are important because of the information they communicate about whether a particular future outcome is likely to occur, with the only *motivating* force (the pull) coming from the subjective value of that future outcome. In the SEU model, for example, when there are two possible future outcomes—"I will have cereal instead of eggs this morning" and "I will have eggs instead of cereal this morning"—a high probability of one outcome (e.g., 80 percent likelihood of having cereal) is *equivalent* to a low probability of the alternative outcome (e.g., 20 percent likelihood of having eggs). In this model, it is the future outcome that matters, and the probabilities are providing the *same information* about what will happen in the future; i.e., my having cereal is more likely to happen than my having eggs.

But what if subjective likelihood has a motivational force *in its own right* because it concerns another way of being effective—truth effectiveness? What if, as James (1948/1890) suggested, high subjective likelihood establishes something as real rather than imaginary?

If this were the case, then a subjective likelihood about a future event could contribute to value not only by providing information about whether *that* specific outcome is likely to happen in the future, but also by affecting strength of engagement *now—preparatory engagement for a future reality*. And this preparatory engagement could affect the value of something *else* in the *present* by intensifying current evaluative reactions. When individuals experience high likelihood, future outcomes feel real. And because they need to prepare now for something that will *really* happen, their engagement in what they are doing in the present is strengthened. And stronger engagement will intensify evaluative reactions to what they are doing now.

From this perspective, then, experiencing high likelihood of some future outcome, by strengthening engagement now, could affect the value of something else in the present. A recent research program investigated these implications (Higgins et al. 2013). In one study, undergraduates believed that they were participating in a marketing study for a new dairy company that was trying to decide what would become their newest flavor of yogurt. In the first part of the study, they tasted two different types of yogurt flavors (labeled A and B). One type of yogurt flavor was pre-tested to be good-tasting (flavored with sugar and nutmeg) and the other was pre-tested to be bad-tasting (flavored with clove). The participants were also told that in the second part of the study they would try either more concentrations of just type A yogurt or more concentrations of just type B yogurt. It will be either A or B.

The likelihood of later trying just Type A or just Type B was expressed using either a *high likelihood expression* (80 percent chance) or a *low likelihood expression* (20 percent chance). For example, if it was probable that participants would later try more concentrations of the good-tasting yogurt A, the high likelihood expression condition said "You have an 80 percent likelihood of later tasting concentrations of yogurt A," whereas the low likelihood expression condition said "You have a 20 percent likelihood of later tasting concentrations of yogurt B"—*different likelihood expressions* (80 percent A vs. 20 percent B) for the *same future probable event* (i.e., it is probable that they will later taste concentrations of yogurt A rather than yogurt B).

Regardless of whether the probability was about tasting the good yogurt in the future or the bad yogurt in the future, describing the future activity as a 80 percent likelihood intensified evaluative reactions to both yogurts in the present more than describing the future activity as a 20 percent likelihood—the good yogurt tasted even better and the bad yogurt tasted even worse when the future was expressed as an 80 percent likelihood of something happening. When the future is expressed as being likely to happen, people prepare for it in the present, and such preparation strengthens engagement in present activities, which intensifies evaluative responses to those activities (both positive and negative responses).

Conclusion

As a psychologist, I believe it is best to think of value as the experience of a force of attraction toward something or repulsion from something. Historically, this experience would

be tied to the hedonic experiences of approaching pleasure and avoiding pain. But this hedonic viewpoint alone is problematic for three major reasons. First, what people find attractive or repulsive is not restricted to experiences of pleasure and pain. Indeed, they will take on pain for the sake of establishing what's real (truth) and managing what happens (control). Second, the hedonic viewpoint is silent on the critical difference between how the promotion and prevention systems approach pleasure and avoid pain, and this difference even changes whether the status quo "0" is experienced as positive or negative. Third, and perhaps most important, the hedonic viewpoint provides a very limited understanding of where value comes from. It fails to appreciate the importance for value of the fit or non-fit between different ways of being effective, and it ignores the contribution of engagement strength to the intensity of positive and negative value. Indeed, it cannot account for how a source of engagement strength that is hedonically unpleasant for everyone, such as an unpleasant background noise, can either decrease *or increase* the positive value of an object depending on whether the way of dealing with the adversity weakens or strengthens engagement in the object-related activity. Because of engagement strength, a person can currently feel good or bad and yet the value of *something else* can be intensified in the opposite direction of how they feel.

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